DCTVU

DC TELEVISION UNIVERSE

Franchise Bible — Volume 11: Crownstone, the Smilleys & the Feud

FORMAT • TONE • CONTINUITY • CANON • TEAMS & FOUNDING ROSTERS

An alternate-history story told through Hollywood trades, headlines,
social media, the internet, and screenplay-format scenes.

Story present: 2010.
Six live-action series + two animated series. One multiverse.

Internal development document. Fictional actors and the individual series to be created in later volumes.

Section 0 — Locked World Rule

STATUS: LOCKED. In our story, **Paramount does not exist. Crownstone Entertainment** fills its role in all of its past, present, and future history: the studio, its corporate parents and mergers, CBS, the Viacom networks, and the 2025 sale. The family that controls it is **the Smilley Family**, filling the role of the Redstone family and its holding company, National Amusements.

Field	Crownstone (2010)
Studio	**Crownstone Pictures**, 5555 Melrose Avenue, Hollywood, on the lot it has occupied since 1926
Logo	A snow-capped peak crowned by a ring of 24 stars: *"The Crown of Hollywood."*
Corporate parents (2010)	**Crownstone-Viacom** (Crownstone Pictures, Nickelodeon, MTV, BET, Comedy Central, VH1) and **CBS Corporation** (CBS, Showtime, Simon & Schuster, and **half of The CW**)
Controlling owner	**Smilley Amusements, Inc.**, the family holding company and a theater chain since 1936. It holds about 80% of the voting shares of both companies.
Chairman	**Charles Smilley** (since June 2001). Age 51 on Jan. 1, 2010.
Smilley family wealth	About $48 billion. Enormous, but not even 3% of Donohue's market value.

Why this matters for the DCTVU: through CBS, the Smilleys own **half of The CW**, the network that airs the DCTVU. **Wonder Woman** launches on **CBS**, a Smilley network. And Marc-Anthony grew up on **Nickelodeon**, also a Smilley network. Charles Smilley has his hands on every part of the franchise.

Section 1 — Crownstone Entertainment: Timeline, 1912–2025

Every Paramount milestone becomes a Crownstone milestone on the same date. The founders and stars are the real historical people; only the company names change.

Date	Event
May 8, 1912	Adolph Zukor founds the **Crown Players Film Company** in New York.
1914	W. W. Hodkinson creates the distributor **Crownstone Pictures Corporation**, and the mountain-and-stars logo is born.
1916	Crown Players merges with Jesse L. Lasky's company to form **Crown Players–Lasky**, with Cecil B. DeMille.
1926	The studio moves to 5555 Melrose Avenue, Hollywood.
May 16, 1929	*Wings* (Crownstone) wins the first Academy Award for Best Picture.
1933–1935	The Depression pushes Crownstone into bankruptcy receivership; it is reorganized as **Crownstone Pictures Inc.** in 1935.
May 3, 1948	**United States v. Crownstone Pictures**: the Supreme Court forces the studios to sell their theater chains. (This ruling becomes the Smilleys' biggest opportunity.)
1956	DeMille's *The Ten Commandments*
1966	Gulf+Western acquires Crownstone.
1967	Crownstone acquires Desilu, adding *Star Trek* and *Mission: Impossible*.
1972–1986	*The Godfather*, *Saturday Night Fever*, *Grease*, *Raiders of the Lost Ark*, *Top Gun*, and on TV *Happy Days* and *Cheers*
1987	**Smilley Amusements acquires Viacom** (MTV, Nickelodeon, Showtime) in a hostile takeover.
1989	Gulf+Western renames itself **Crownstone Communications**.
1993–1994	**The bidding war:** Smilley's Viacom fights QVC *and Donohue* for Crownstone (see Section 3). Viacom wins on **Fri., Mar. 11, 1994**, deep in debt.
1997	*Titanic* (co-produced with 20th Century Fox)
2000	Viacom and CBS complete their merger.
Dec. 31, 2005	The empire splits in two, **Crownstone-Viacom** and **CBS Corporation**, both still controlled by the Smilleys.
2006	Crownstone acquires DreamWorks Pictures. **CBS and Warner Bros. launch The CW** (Sept. 18).
May 2, 2008	Crownstone releases Marvel's *Iron Man*.
2010 (story present)	**Donohue buys Crownstone's Marvel distribution rights**, taking back the franchise Crownstone helped launch. The trades call it “the Marvel Heist.”
Mar. 2012	Crownstone's 100th anniversary year begins; the centennial gala is held May 8, 2012 (see Section 4).
Dec. 4, 2019	The two halves remerge as **CrownstoneCBS**.
2022	Renamed **Crownstone Global**. CBS sells most of its CW stake to Nexstar in October.
Aug. 7, 2025	**Skydance Media completes its merger with Crownstone.** After 38 years, the Smilley family loses control of the empire.

Section 2 — The Smilley Family

Generation	Person	Life	Role
1	**Moses Smilley**	Born Mar. 2, 1899, Kansas City; died Nov. 9, 1987, at 88	Founder of Smilley Amusements. **The man who sold Mickey Mouse** (see Section 3).
2	**Theodore “Teddy” Smilley** and wife **Lorraine Smilley**	Born Feb. 12, 1924; died Sun., June 3, 2001, at 77	A Crownstone contract star in the 1950s, then the businessman who built the empire
3	**Charles Smilley** and wife **Vivian (née Hart)**	Charles born Mar. 14, 1958; Vivian born July 2, 1961	Chairman since 2001; Vivian controls the family's image
4	**Theo II, Josie, and Esther**	Born 1985, 1988, and 1992	The acting heirs; Esther is the biggest star

How the Smilleys built Crownstone

- **1936: theaters for Black audiences.** Shut out of white-owned theaters, Moses Smilley opens the **Smilley Palace** in Kansas City's 18th & Vine district, a first-run movie house for Black audiences. By 1946 he owns 61 theaters and drive-ins across the South and Midwest, the largest Black-owned theater chain in America.
- **1948: the opening.** When the Supreme Court forces Crownstone and the other studios to sell their theaters, Moses buys the divested theaters, white neighborhoods included, at fire-sale prices. Smilley Amusements becomes a national chain.
- **1950s: the star son.** Teddy Smilley signs with Crownstone in 1951 and becomes one of the first Black leading men under a studio contract. He learns the studio from the inside, and he promises his father he'll own it one day.
- **1987–1994: the takeovers.** Teddy takes over Viacom in 1987 and Crownstone in 1994. He keeps his promise, but too late for Moses, who dies in 1987.
- **2001: the crown passes.** Charles inherits the chairmanship at 43. He's a fine actor and an Academy Award nominee, but people always say he's “not his father,” and he knows it.

Section 3 — Why the Smilleys Hate the Donohues

> **Three generations, three wounds.** The Smilleys believe the Donohues stole their fortune, nearly destroyed their business, and robbed them of their glory. Every Smilley child grows up hearing the same three words: *"The stolen mouse."*

Wound 1: The Stolen Mouse (1923–1928)

Moses Smilley grew up three blocks from the Donohue brothers in Kansas City. In 1923 he put in $500, the largest single investment in the Donohue Brothers Cartoon Studio, and he worked as its first cameraman. Later that year, Gus Donohue made Moses a written promise of **a third of the company** if he stayed through "the hard years."

In 1928 the studio lost its first hit character to its distributor, and it nearly went under. Moses panicked. A white-owned distributor offered to buy the studio, on one condition: its Black founders had to disappear from the credits. Moses begged the brothers to sell, and they refused. On **Friday, October 12, 1928**, Moses sold his shares back to Gus for **$3,000 in cash**.

Thirty-seven days later, on Nov. 18, 1928, *Steamboat Willie* premiered. Moses died believing that Gus already had the synchronized-sound reels hidden in a back room and let him sell anyway. The Donohues have always said Moses walked away of his own free will. The truth: the reels did exist, Gus did know, and Gus did tell Moses, but Moses left the room before Gus finished. That's a secret for later in our story.

The price: a third of Donohue Entertainment would be worth more than **$3.3 trillion** in 2010. Instead, Moses's descendants are the only Central Avenue families missing from the Founders' Trust.

Wound 2: The Blackout (1979–1981)

In 1977, Teddy Smilley's 900 theaters demanded that Donohue cut its share of ticket revenue. Victor Donohue, CEO at 31, didn't negotiate. From June 1, 1979, he pulled every Donohue film out of every Smilley theater for 22 months, including summer re-releases and the first two Superman films. Teddy had to sell 214 theaters and the family's Kansas City home. Victor sent flowers to the closing of the original Smilley Palace. Teddy kept the card in his wallet until he died.

Wound 3: The Spite Bid (1993–1994)

When Teddy finally went after Crownstone in 1993, Victor Donohue joined the bidding war with no real intention of winning. He only wanted to drive up the price. Donohue's bids pushed the final price up by about $3 billion, and Smilley's Viacom won with crushing debt. Charles, 35, watched his father sign the papers and then collapse in a stairwell. Teddy lived another seven years. The Smilleys still call it **"the heart attack Victor bought."**

The truce and the end of the truce (1997–2007)

- **1997, the Polo Lounge truce:** the two patriarchs, Teddy (73) and Victor (51), quietly agree to a cease-fire. That's why little Esther Smilley was allowed to start her career on Donohue films and the Donohue Channel.
- **June 2001:** Teddy dies. Charles honors the truce, but he never signed it himself.
- **Thursday, March 1, 2007: the end of the truce.** Natasha Bullock moves her son, Marc-Anthony Bullock (15), the biggest star on Nickelodeon (Smilley-owned), to the Donohue Channel's *Prodigy*, and Tayia Boyd

goes with him. Nickelodeon's ratings drop sharply. Charles (48) had personally made Marc the face of the network. He considers it a betrayal, and the war is back on.

- **2009:** Charles orders Esther (17) to end her Donohue contract and “come home” to Crownstone. *Summer Song* (2008), opposite Marc-Anthony, is her last Donohue project.

Section 4 — Why Charles Smilley Will Hate Marc-Anthony

Charles Smilley hates the Donohues out of family history. He comes to hate **Marc-Anthony Bullock** personally, because Marc-Anthony is everything Charles was never allowed to be: loved, gifted, free, and better at it. Marc-Anthony doesn't hate anyone, and that's what Charles can't forgive.

Date	Event	Charles's age
Thu., Mar. 1, 2007	**The Defection.** Marc-Anthony leaves Charles's Nickelodeon for the Donohue Channel. It starts out as business.	48
Sun., Jan. 17, 2010	**The Globes.** At 17, Esther tells her father that Marc-Anthony is her best friend, and she won't stop speaking to him. (See the scene below.)	51
Tue., May 8, 2012	**The Centennial Joke.** Esther pushes for peace, and Crownstone invites Marc-Anthony (20) to perform at its 100th-anniversary gala. His unfiltered set ends with a joke about Crownstone's 100 years and “the one mouse that got away.” The audience roars; Charles is humiliated in front of the whole industry. Marc-Anthony sincerely apologizes, but Charles never accepts it.	54
Mon., Sept. 16, 2013	**Free the Nick Kids.** Marc-Anthony learns that a loophole in Crownstone's old Nickelodeon contracts let the company keep residuals owed to former child actors, his own early co-stars among them. Bending the rules, he quietly funds a legal team, digs up internal memos, and supports a lawsuit under California's Coogan Law. Crownstone pays a **$1.2 billion** settlement, and Charles has to testify under oath. To the public, Marc-Anthony is a hero; to Charles, he's the boy who put the Smilley name on a witness stand.	55
Mon., May 16, 2016	**The Move.** Charles's own CBS sends *Wonder Woman*, the show he approved because it was a Smilley network, to The CW. That puts Esther right next to Marc-Anthony and The Flash in the DCTVU. Charles's own company has delivered his daughter to his enemy.	58
Sun., Feb. 14, 2021*	**Together.** After twenty years of friendship, Esther (28) and Marc-Anthony (29) become a couple.	62
Tue., May 10, 2022	**The Twins.** Emma and Victoria are born before their parents marry, and the tabloids turn on Charles's “good girl” family image. Worse for Charles: only blood descendants of Neil Donohue can inherit the Donohue family's controlling shares. His only grandchildren by his youngest daughter are **Donohue heirs**, and the Smilley line has been absorbed into the family it hates.	64
Sat., June 17, 2023*	**The Wedding.** Esther marries Marc-Anthony. Charles doesn't attend. Vivian does, then leaves early in tears.	65
Thu., Aug. 7, 2025	**The Fall.** With Crownstone deep in debt, the Smilleys lose control when Skydance's merger closes. In the same years, Marc-Anthony's fortune passes $990 billion. Charles convinces himself that the Bullocks' success drained Crownstone's talent, audiences, and his daughter, and he blames Marc-Anthony for all of it.	67

* Dates marked with an asterisk are proposed; you gave only the year. Change them anytime.

Charles's war (after 2022): stop at nothing

- **Taking the fortune:** he revives Moses's 1928 claim to a third of the company as *Smilley v. Donohue*, which would reach into Marc-Anthony's fortune and the Donohue shares. He also tries to gain control of Emma's and Victoria's trusts as their grandfather, and urges Esther to file for divorce so she can claim a settlement.

- **Ruining the career:** he leaks out-of-context clips of Marc-Anthony's comedy, funds smear campaigns about his rule-bending as “lawlessness,” pressures talent through his remaining industry relationships, and files lawsuits meant to tie up Marc-Anthony's productions.
- **The weakness Marc-Anthony doesn't use:** Marc-Anthony knows the truth about the stolen mouse (that Gus did tell Moses about the sound reels), and he refuses to use it to humiliate a dead man. His kindness is the one weapon Charles can't counter.
- **Esther in the middle:** she loves her father and chooses her husband. Every family holiday is a battlefield.

Opening Scene — The Seed of It All

Sunday, January 17, 2010, 9:47 PM PT. The 67th Golden Globe Awards, Beverly Hilton, Beverly Hills. Esther Smilley (17), Charles Smilley (51), Vivian Smilley (48), Marc-Anthony Bullock (18).

INT. BEVERLY HILTON — SERVICE HALLWAY — NIGHT

Muffled applause through the walls. ESTHER SMILLEY, 17, in a borrowed-from-Grandma vintage gown, slips out of the ballroom, grinning, phone in hand. CHARLES SMILLEY, 51, silver at the temples and furious, steps out behind her. VIVIAN SMILLEY, 48, follows a beat later, checking for cameras.

CHARLES

Where are you going?

ESTHER

To find Marc. He just lost to a man more than three times his age and he's going to make a joke about it, and I want to be there for the joke.

CHARLES

You sat at the Crownstone table tonight. You're a Smilley tonight. You don't congratulate a Donohue.

ESTHER

He's a Bullock, Daddy. And he's my friend. Since I was eight.

VIVIAN

(soft, warning)

Charles. Not here.

CHARLES

His grandfather sent flowers to your great-grandfather's theater the day it closed. Did you know that? He sent *flowers*.

ESTHER

Marc wasn't born yet.

Down the hallway, a door bangs open. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK, 18 (twelve days ago), tie undone, holding a slice of the ballroom cake on a napkin, spots them, and lights up.

MARC-ANTHONY

Mr. Smilley! Mrs. Smilley! I lost! I brought cake. Losers get cake now, it's a new rule, I made it up thirty seconds ago.

He holds the napkin out to Charles. A long beat. Charles doesn't take it.

CHARLES

Congratulations on your nomination.

MARC-ANTHONY

(still smiling, genuinely)

Thank you, sir. Your daughter's the best actor in this building, by the way. Don't tell my mom I said that.

Charles turns and walks back into the ballroom. Vivian lingers half a second, almost smiles, then follows. Esther takes the cake.

ESTHER

He hates you.

MARC-ANTHONY

Nobody hates me. He just hasn't gotten to know me yet.

He means it completely. Esther laughs. Behind the ballroom doors, Charles watches them through the gap. HOLD on his face.

CUT TO BLACK.

> **[Twitter — @HollywoodWhisperer — Sun., Jan. 17, 2010, 10:06 PM PT]** Spotted at the Globes: Charles Smilley turning down CAKE from Marc-Anthony Bullock in a hallway. The Smilley–Donohue cold war is NOT over, y'all. #GoldenGlobes